

## CHAPTER TWENTY

# Forgiveness Is Not the Same as Trust

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This is the second HIGHEST RISK lesson. Mr. Tate is in the room.

This is Kezia's chapter.

We have not talked about Kezia much in this book yet. We have mentioned her. We know, from Book One, that Kezia lives with her grandmother, and that there is a grown-up in Kezia's life who used to be a regular part of her family and who is not anymore. We know that, in first grade, Kezia learned the line that her grandmother had been trying to teach her: *I forgive them. But that does not mean they can come back. Forgiveness and trust are not the same.*

It has been two years since Kezia learned that line.

A lot has happened in two years.

The grown-up — the one who is not allowed in their house — has, in the last six months, started writing letters to Kezia again. Not just birthday cards. Real letters. Saying *I am sorry. I have changed. I am doing the work. I want to see you. Please can I come back.*

The letters have been intense. Kezia has been reading them. Her grandmother has been reading them. They have been talking about them at the kitchen table.

Kezia, who is nine now, has been carrying a question.

The question is: *What do I do if somebody who hurt us seems to really be different now? Do I let them back in? Is forgiveness supposed to lead to letting them back in eventually? Or are forgiveness and trust really separate forever?*

She has not been able to figure it out.

This is the chapter where the lesson gives her the answer — or rather, the lesson gives her the framework, and the answer is hers to write.

Ms. Calloway began the lesson on a Tuesday morning. Mr. Tate was already in the back of the room with his clipboard. He had been there before she came in.

"Friends. Today's lesson is one of the most important lessons we will do all year. I want you to listen carefully."

She wrote on the board:

FORGIVENESS | TRUST

"Forgiveness and trust are two different things. They look similar from the outside. They are not the same on the inside. Almost every adult you know mixes them up — sometimes for their whole lives. We are going to learn the difference today."

She built the chart.

| FORGIVENESS | TRUST |

|---|---|

| Inside you | Between people |

| For YOUR peace | For SAFETY |

| You can give it alone | The other person earns it |

| It is a gift to yourself | It is never owed |

| Always available | Has to be earned, sometimes over years |

| You decide | You decide AND they decide |

"Forgiveness is inside you. It is something you do for your own peace. You can give it without ever telling the other person. You can give it after they are gone. You can give it

after they have died. You can give it from across the country. You can give it without ever seeing them again."

"Trust is different. Trust is between people. It is about safety. It is about whether you are going to let somebody back into your life. Trust is earned. It is earned through changed behavior — not changed words, not changed apologies, changed behavior over time. Trust takes weeks, months, sometimes years to rebuild. Sometimes it does not rebuild at all. And that is okay."

She paused.

She said the most important sentence of the lesson next, the same sentence she had said two years ago in Room 12.

"You can forgive someone — AND still choose not to be close to them. That is not mean. That is wise."

Mr. Tate, in the back of the room, nodded.

"And here is the part that some adults forget to tell kids. You are NEVER required to forgive someone who is still hurting you. If somebody is still being mean. If somebody is still doing the thing. Forgiveness is for AFTER. For when the thing is over. For when you are SAFE. Safe always comes first. Always."

She wrote it again:

**SAFE COMES FIRST. ALWAYS.**

The room was quiet.

Kezia raised her hand.

"Yes, Kezia?"

"Ms. Calloway. What if the person — what if the person seems like they really have changed? Like, they have done the work? They keep telling you they have. What do you do then?"

Ms. Calloway, who had been waiting for this question — she had been waiting for it for three years, in different forms — took a breath.

"Kezia. That is a really important question. I am going to answer it carefully."

"Okay."

"Forgiveness, you can give right away — if you want to. Forgiveness is yours. You can decide to give it whenever the time is right for you, regardless of what the other person is doing."

"Trust is different. Trust comes back slowly, if it comes back. And trust comes back not from the person saying they have changed. Trust comes back from time and evidence. It comes back from the person doing the right thing, over and over, in many situations, over a long stretch — when no one is watching, when it costs them something, when there is no reward for doing right. The behavior has to prove the change. The words are not enough. The words are never enough."

"And here is the most important part. Even when somebody really has changed — even when they really, really have — you are still not required to let them back into your life. Their change is theirs. Whether they get to be close to you is yours. Those are two different decisions."

"Some people change and earn their way back into the lives of people they hurt. Some people change and are still kept at a distance, because the people they hurt have decided — for their own reasons, which do not have to be explained — that the closeness is not safe to attempt. Both choices are valid. The choice belongs to the person who was hurt. Always."

She paused.

"Kezia. If you ever — and I am being general, this could be anyone's question — if you ever have a grown-up who is asking to come back into your life, after they have hurt you, here is what I would tell you."

"One. You decide. Not them. Not anybody else. You."

"Two. You ask: *do I feel safe?* Not *do I think they are different.* Not *do I want them to be different.* Do I, in my body, feel safe with them? If the answer is anything less than a clear yes — the answer is no, for now."

"Three. You can let them in gradually, in tiny pieces, if you want to try. A short letter first. A short phone call later. A short visit, with another trusted adult present, a long time after. You do not have to do it all at once. You can take five years to decide. They have to wait."

"Four. You can change your mind. If you let them in a little, and it does not feel safe — you pull back. You do not owe them an explanation. You owe yourself your safety. You owe yourself your peace."

"And five — most importantly — you talk to a trusted adult through every step. This is not a decision a nine-year-old makes alone. This is not a decision a fifteen-year-old makes alone. This is not a decision a forty-year-old makes alone. You bring help. You bring your grandmother, or your other parent, or your counselor, or your therapist. You bring the people who know your story and who will tell you the truth about what they see."

Kezia listened.

She did not say anything for a minute. Then she said, in a quiet steady voice:

"My grandma and I have been getting letters from the person we are not close to anymore. They say they have changed. They want to come back. We have not decided yet."

Ms. Calloway did not flinch. The class did not look at Kezia. Mr. Tate, in the back, had been ready for this. He had been ready for this for years.

"Kezia. Thank you for telling us. Can I ask if you want to talk about it with Mr. Tate and me after class? Just the three of us?"

Not in front of the room."

"Yes, please."

"Okay. We will. After class."

She moved the lesson along. The other kids did the worksheet. The room got quiet. Kezia did her own worksheet, although she did not really see the words on the paper.

At the end of class, the other kids gathered their things and went to lunch. Kezia stayed at her table. Ms. Calloway and Mr. Tate came over. Mr. Tate pulled up a chair, the way he did, slowly, without crowding.

"Kezia. Hi."

"Hi."

"Tell us about the letters."

Kezia took a long breath.

"They started in the summer. The first one was just a card. Birthday card. But it had a letter folded inside. A long one. They said they have been getting help. They said they have been going to a group for two years. They said they wanted to start by writing — not by visiting, just writing — and see if Grandma and I would write back."

"Did you write back?"

"Grandma did. Just one short letter. Saying *we got your letter. We are reading. We are not ready to see you. We will keep reading.*"

"Okay."

"Then more letters came. About one every month. They are about — about the work the person is doing. About the things they have figured out. About apologies for specific things. Some of the specific things, Grandma did not know they remembered. The letters have been — they have been real."

Mr. Tate nodded.

"How are you feeling about them?"

Kezia thought about this for a long time.

"I think — part of me is glad. The letters are softer than the person ever was. I think the person really is doing the work. I do not think the letters are fake. I have read enough of them now. They sound like a different person."

"But?"

"But — when I imagine them coming over, I do not feel safe. My body does not feel safe. I do not know why exactly. But I do not feel safe."

Mr. Tate did not jump in.

"And — and I feel guilty about that. Because if they really did change, and I keep saying no, am I being mean? Am I being unforgiving?"

Ms. Calloway leaned forward.

"Kezia. Listen carefully. You are not being mean. You are not being unforgiving. Your body is telling you something real. Your body has not forgotten. Your body remembers what your brain has worked very hard, with your grandmother's help, to put into some kind of order. The body knows."

"You can forgive somebody — in your heart, in your mind, in your prayers if you pray — and still not feel safe with them. That feeling-not-safe is information. It is not a failure of forgiveness. It is your nervous system protecting you. It is good information."

Mr. Tate added, gently, "Kezia. Some adults will tell you, at some point in your life, that if you have really forgiven someone, you would be ready to let them close again. Those adults are wrong. They are confusing forgiveness with trust. Forgiveness is in your heart. Trust is in your body and in your life. The body gets to vote."

Kezia nodded.

"What do we do? About the letters?"

Ms. Calloway said, "What does your grandmother think?"

"She is — she is glad they are getting help. She is glad they are writing. She has been writing back, short notes, every couple of months. She has not invited them over. She says she does not know yet if she ever will. She says she does not have to decide everything right now."

"That sounds like exactly the right approach, Kezia. Your grandmother is doing what wise grandmothers do — taking it slow. There is no rush. There is no schedule. The person waited a long time before doing the work. They can wait a long time while you and your grandmother decide what comes next."

"And Kezia — if the answer ends up being *we are never going to be close again, but we wish you well from a long way away* — that is a complete answer. That is a whole answer. The person can be loved and not invited in. The person can be forgiven and not trusted. The two are not the same thing."

Kezia said, in a very small voice, "What if I just — never feel safe? What if my body never says yes?"

Mr. Tate said, "Then your body never says yes. And you live your life without that person being close. And you are okay. Many, many people live their lives without certain family members being close. They are not broken. They are not failures at forgiveness. They are just people who decided, for very real reasons, that closeness was not safe. You will be okay. Your grandmother will be okay. The person you are not close to will be okay too — they will keep doing their work, and the work is good for them regardless of whether you are close. They do not get to need closeness with you in order to keep doing the work. The work is its own reward."

Kezia let out a long breath.

She felt — and this surprised her — she felt *permitted*. Like an adult had walked into her brain and given her a permission slip she had been waiting for without knowing.

The permission slip said: *You do not have to invite them back. You do not have to feel guilty about not inviting them back. The not-inviting-back is not unforgiveness. The not-inviting-back is wisdom.*

She breathed in. She breathed out.

"Okay," she said.

"Okay?"

"Okay. I am going to tell Grandma what you said. Tonight. We can keep doing what we are doing. Reading the letters. Not deciding yet."

"That sounds perfect, Kezia."

"Can I — can I come talk to you again? If I need to?"

"Anytime. You raise your hand. Or you ask Mr. Patel. Or you come find me. Anytime."

She nodded. She stood up.

"Thank you, Ms. Calloway. Thank you, Mr. Tate."

"You are welcome, Kezia. You did really hard work today."

She went to lunch.

That night, at dinner, she told her grandmother everything. Her grandmother put her fork down. Her grandmother listened. When Kezia was done, her grandmother said, *baby. You said it better than I ever could have. We are not deciding everything tonight. We are not deciding everything this year. We are reading the letters. We are not closing the door. And we are not opening it. We are just — listening, slowly, with our eyes open. That is the right way.*

Kezia hugged her grandmother for a long time.

That is the chapter.

Forgiveness and trust are different. Safety always comes first. The body gets to vote. The not-inviting-back is wisdom.

These are the four sentences. If you carry them with you, you are ahead of most adults.

— J.A.R.